

amounts due to differing performances over the year. The last thing you want to do is have a team divided by jealousy just because you forgot to add the “\$” symbol when sharing the folder that contained the aforementioned file! Even if you don’t think it’s that big a deal, your bosses might not agree.

This however, is a very simple example! Perhaps none of us are stupid enough to do something like that. However, do you know there are tons of other ways you might unknowingly compromise the security and stability of your company? All it takes is a PC in the hands of a naïve employee to ruin things, and we hope that putting this article in his or her hands might solve some of those problems.

The Beginner Level

The first step is to secure your computer. More often than not, your PC is just *your* PC! There’s no one else who is supposed to use it, and probably, in larger companies, a systems admin (SysAdmin) sitting somewhere far away watching characters (data and IPs) stream across his screen. To him (or her), you’re just a number associated with the network IP or MAC address you were allotted. Anything that happens on that system is attributed to you, and, in the event of a disaster, all the protesting in the universe will not convince the SysAdmin that it just wasn’t you trying to access all those confidential files from your machine!

It’s as simple as walking away from your seat without locking your computer! If someone really wanted to get you into trouble (or keep themselves out of trouble) all they would have to do is look for a free PC. When the coast is clear, and a malicious user is sure of not being noticed, he (or she) would use your computer for nefarious purposes—trying to access restricted security areas (files or folders), do some damage to a network or file server, steal data, or even something as silly as surf for pornography.

In the end, whatever is done on your computer by others will be attributed to you. If we haven’t made ourselves clear, lock your computers when leaving your desk. Put boot passwords to prevent unauthorised startup, and if you use Windows XP, make sure the default Administrator password isn’t left blank!

If your office has shifts, and computers are

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shared by multiple users (a typical BPO setup), make sure to create separate logins for each user that uses a particular machine, and allocate each machine to only a fixed number of users. In this case (BPOs), chances are this has already been done at your office, or you use a system that makes each user log in to identify themselves. Just make sure to stress on the importance of each user keeping his or her password to themselves, and not share it with friends.

E-mail Security

Though e-mail is generally considered the least secure of all daily tasks, there’s still a basic level of security you should adhere to. You need to make sure that your e-mail client is secured with your anti-virus, because the last thing you want to do is be the cause of a big, bad virus entering the office network.

Viruses apart, there’s still the need to keep e-mails private. Whether it’s accolades or criticism you receive from your bosses, personal mails from your significant other, jokes from your friends, or confidential information passed on by your bosses and colleagues, you don’t want just anyone accessing these mails. Make sure to use an e-mail client that offers password protection for both the e-mail client as well as the stored e-mails.

Microsoft Outlook is perhaps the most popular e-mail client, and it has both features. Just make sure you password-protect both the ‘outlook.pst’ as well as the ‘archive.pst’ files. You can do this easily by right-clicking on your ‘Personal Folders’ folder and selecting ‘Properties’. Go to General > Advanced > Change Password. Now enter a new password and click ‘OK’.

Password Strengths

More often than not, we use passwords that are not really secure or creative. Most people use passwords that are specific key combinations, such as “asdf” or “abc123”. Such passwords are not hard to guess, and any password cracker out there will do so in a jiffy. What you need to do is make sure that passwords are a mixture of numbers and letters, have no obvious sequence, and are not public knowledge. For example, if your name is Ram Rao, with the username set to “Ram”, the first password people will try is “Rao”; the very next thing will be “r40”, “ra0”, “r4o”, and other combina-

Proper Policies

Bigger businesses will have heard of the ISO 17799 security standard. Getting ISO 17799 certification can mean the difference between being thought of as a small-time player and a ‘proper’ corporate entity. For those of you who haven’t heard of it, here’s a brief description, as taken from ISO’s (International Organisation of Standardization, a.k.a. International Standardization Organisation) Web site www.iso.org:

“ISO/IEC 17799:2005 establishes guidelines and general principles for initiating, implementing, maintaining, and improving information security management

in an organization. The objectives outlined provide general guidance on the commonly accepted goals of information security management. ISO/IEC 17799:2005 contains best practices of control objectives and controls in the following areas of information security management:

- ☐ Security policy;
- ☐ Organization of information security;
- ☐ Asset management;
- ☐ Human resources security;
- ☐ Physical and environmental security;
- ☐ Communications and operations management;
- ☐ Access control;

- ☐ Information systems acquisition, development and maintenance;
- ☐ Information security incident management;
- ☐ Business continuity management;
- ☐ Compliance.

You can find a lot more information at www.17799.com, which is a community forum for the standard, and www.iso17799software.com. The entire standard description is not available for free download, and you will have to pay approximately \$155 (Rs 6,800) to get it. If interested, you can buy and download it from <http://snipurl.com/iso17799/>.